

WE WANT 'BANK OF BARODA RASHTRABHASHA SAMMAN' TO BE A NATIONAL INSTITUTION

Bank of Baroda (Bank), one of India's leading public sector banks, announced the long-list of 12 Novels, nominated for the first edition of the 'Bank of Baroda Rashtrabhasha Samman' Award 2023. The unique award has been instituted to recognize and promote literary works in various Indian languages as well as to make the best Indian literature available to Hindi readers through translations.

Speaking to India Today, **Mr. Sanjiv Chadha, Managing Director & CEO, Bank of Baroda** said "India is a diverse country – a melting pot of cultures, religions and languages. And in its diversity lies its strength and distinctiveness. We believe that the promotion of literature across Indian languages helps strengthen our multiculturalism."

What is the rationale of BoB constituting such an award?

As you are aware, our Bank was founded on 20th July 1908 by Maharaja Sayajirao Gaekwad III – one of the greatest patrons of arts, music, literature and performing arts. He founded several cultural and educational institutions besides being a great collector of classical Indian painters like Raja Ravi Varma. So, the inspiration to promote art and literature is ingrained in the Bank's DNA.

The Bank has been part of several acclaimed art and cultural festivals such as Prithvi and Kala Ghoda Arts Festival in Mumbai among others. In the literary arena, we have been associated with the Jaipur Literature Festival. So, we want to extend this mission of promoting India's rich cultural heritage by supporting our language literature in line with our progress as a nation. The 'Bank of Baroda Rashtrabhasha Samman' will now be an integral part of Indian language and literature promotion.

Does 'Bank of Baroda Rashtrabhasha Samman' mean promotion of Hindi language and literature?

Let me explain few aspects of about the national language or Rashtra Bhasha and State languages or Rajya Bhasha of India. The Eight Schedule of the Indian Constitution lists 22 languages, known as scheduled languages with due recognition, status and official encouragement. Some of them are known as classical languages for their rich heritage and independent nature. Thus, these are all national languages or Rashtra Bhashas while the official language is Hindi.

Thus, this award intends to respect, promote and advance all our national languages by promoting literary works, originally written in them, and also by translating them into Hindi. So, the award will be presented to both the original author of the selected novel and the translator who has translated the book to Hindi from the original regional languages. We have received entries from Hindi translators as well as publishers. This way, we believe all languages are treated equally and with due respect.

How does it help writers in Indian languages other than Hindi?

The award promotes the mutual interchange amongst Indian languages and seeks to make the best Indian literary works available to a very large appreciative audience. Moreover, it gives a national platform to talented Indian writers from different parts of the country and will give a boost to Indian language literature as well as encourage literary translations.

The original author of a novel and the Hindi translator of the same will be honoured with awards that carry ₹21.00 lakh and ₹15.00 lakh respectively. In addition to this, authors and Hindi translators of the next five shortlisted works will also be recognised and be given ₹3.00 lakh and ₹2.00 lakh respectively. We believe that this is perhaps the highest prize money for a literary award since it is our desire to support all those talented writers to feel rewarded and appreciated by the people of India.

Who decides the winners? Can you throw some light on the jury?

Since this is a recognition of national significance with much interest across our national languages, we wanted to ensure very high credibility in the selection of these works. We have an elite jury of eminent literary personalities, headed by none other than the Booker Prize winner, Smt. Geetanjali Shree. The other four jury members are Mr. Arun Kamal, an Indian poet; Mr. Pushpesh Pant, an academic and historian; Ms. Anamika, a contemporary Indian poet and novelist; and Mr. Prabhat Ranjan, a Hindi fiction writer and translator. We believe this could be the most distinguished jury that could be put together at the moment.

When will you announce the winners? What's the process ahead?

We have announced the long-list of 12 Novels, nominated for the first edition of the 'Bank of Baroda Rashtrabhasha Samman' Award 2023 this week. The Bank had initiated the process of inviting nominations during the period March-April 2023 and received several entries written in different Indian languages, from which the jury has prepared a long-list of 12 books. From this list, the jury will select the winner and five other runners-up who will be honoured. The winner of the Award will be announced on 11th June, 2023 in Delhi.

बैंक ऑफ़ बड़ौदा राष्ट्रभाषा सम्मान

राष्ट्र की भाषाएँ, राष्ट्र की धरोहर.

What is the way forward for the award?

With the co-operation of all art and literature lovers across India, we believe we can make this a national institution, coveted for its prestige and literary eminence.

How does this help the Bank in terms of core activities?

No doubt, the key objective is to enrich our national languages by nurturing our writers in line with the tradition of our founder. But from the core banking perspective, we understand the importance of all our languages for our customers who find extreme comfort in conversing or engaging with the bank in respective languages. As you are aware, around 93% of the calls to our call centres are in national languages which proved instrumental in enhancing our financial inclusion efforts. Now, from the future perspective, the Bank is aware of the need to develop technology and utilize the power of the local languages for a greater engagement with our growing customer base.

